

Written Homework Assignment #4

Something Completely Different

You have all heard me talk about the idea of treating creation of software as an art form or as the craft of creating applications. But what does that really mean? What is the difference between *art* and *craft*? IS there a difference? What does the terms mean TO YOU? What does the term well-crafted software mean in your opinion?

The dictionary definition for **ART** is:

The conscious use of the imagination in the production of objects intended to be contemplated or appreciated as beautiful, as in the arrangement of forms, sounds, or words.

In contrast, the dictionary definition for **CRAFT** is:

Skill in doing or making something, as in the arts; proficiency..

You can see how close the dictionary definitions are, but that doesn't mean they are the same thing. As the saying goes, *C*lose only counts in horseshoes. It is obvious that you can't create art without some kind of skill; neither can you craft something that is beautiful, elegant, and skillfully made without some element of art to it.

To help you find out the difference, this assignment is going to have you jump outside of your comfort zone a bit. You will head over to the College of Communications and Fine Arts [CFA] where there is a great art museum called [Laband Art Gallery](#). From January 29th until March 28th there is an art exhibit of works by Noni Olabisi called When Lightning Strikes which includes more than 40 artworks honoring Olabisi's work as an artist, muralist, and mentor, and

celebrates her three masterpiece murals in Los Angeles: Freedom Won't Wait (1992); To Protect and Serve (1995); and Troubled Island (2003).

Your task for this assignment is to pick one of the works shown, then look at it carefully and decide if, *IN YOUR OPINION*, it represents **ART** or **CRAFT**. Write a paragraph that describes your thinking on the piece that answers the following nine questions:

- Is this piece ART or CRAFT? Is it perhaps BOTH?
- What about this selection drew you to it or caught your eye?
- What kinds of *feelings* does the piece elicit when you see it?
- What do you think the artist is trying to say with the piece?
- What does the piece say to YOU personally regardless of what the artist is saying?
- Do you think Artificial Intelligence could produce something of equal meaning?
- How do you think you might apply the concept of art or craft to your software designs and coding?
- Do you think software creation SHOULD BE an art? Should it be a craft?
- What kinds of questions do you ask yourself about your design/code? Do you go back to it after it is working and re-factor it to make it *clean*?

THERE ARE NO WRONG ANSWERS HERE. This is an opinion piece which is intended to get you thinking about YOUR software efforts and how engaged you are with your products, beyond simply making it work.

In my opinion, To Protect and Serve (1995) by Noni Olabisi is both art and craft. The art is the beauty and the message the work is trying to tell. The craft is the mastery of the many skills required to execute on a mural of that size. This selection drew me in with its scale and the very city, Los Angeles aesthetic. The images are bold and clearly have many stories to tell, such as the person tied up and the people struggling for food. When looking at the piece, I feel somewhat tense, as the point I feel is to make the viewer face uncomfortable truths. I think the artist is trying to make a point about how the Black community has faced much police brutality, especially with the title "To Protect and Serve". The general message that I get from this piece, besides the intended message, is that a motto such as "To Protect and Serve" can't always be trusted and we must hold everyone accountable. I don't think AI can produce something of similar meaning, as it cannot feel the emotions to make a genuine social commentary without just mimicking things that have already been said. I might apply concepts from art to software by being intentional and imaginative when considering how users or other developers interact with my projects or code. The concept of craft would be making code effective and efficient. Software development should certainly be a craft, as it is a high skill task. In my opinion, if human experience and imagination are incorporated well, it can also be considered art. I ask myself whether code is comprehensible and efficient, and I do revisit it after it works to refactor and clean it up